

Trying to tell if someone will make a good roommate before you move in

8 findings · 12-step checklist · 6 sources · cheatgrid.com

Liking someone tells you little about living with them. **Follow-through** decides how a household runs, and chemistry gives you no read on it.

THE GOAL

You're gathering better evidence before you move in. Ask them about one specific chore or bill from a past place, and how it actually got handled.

CHECKLIST

Sitting down with them, before you move in, to actually talk through how living together will work.

- ☐ Say up front that you want to spend a few minutes on the practical stuff, not just catching up.
- ☐ Pick two or three concrete things to cover, like chores, guests, and quiet hours, so it doesn't drift.
- ☐ Bring up a specific chore or bill from a past place and ask how it actually got handled.
- ☐ If they mention something they let slide before, ask what they actually did about it, not just how it turned out.
- ☐ Name one small thing that already bothers you, **out loud**, in one sentence.
- ☐ If they brush it off or get defensive, say what you noticed instead of letting it drop.
- ☐ If they take it seriously and offer a fix, agree on the fix out loud, right then.
- ☐ Ask whether anything about their plans, like their move-in date or schedule, has changed since you first said yes.
- ☐ If this pairing wasn't fully either of your choice, **say that plainly** instead of pretending it was.
- ☐ Write down whatever you agreed on somewhere you'll both see it again, not just in the conversation.
- ☐ Set an actual date, in the next few weeks after you move in, to check back in on how it's going.
- ☐ End the conversation by naming one thing you're genuinely looking forward to about living together.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1** A smooth household usually comes down to something less flattering than chemistry: **who actually follows through**.
- 2** Over a year of living together, you and your roommate tend to grow more alike emotionally, and whichever of you has less pull in the relationship usually does more of the adjusting to get there.
- 3** Ending up with a roommate of a different race than you doesn't by itself make the relationship worse.

What actually tells you this will work

KNOW

Really having a lot in common with someone predicts attraction early on, but that stops holding once you're already living together.

Feeling like you click keeps predicting attraction even once you're settled in together; really overlapping in interests and habits stops predicting it. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

A smooth household usually comes down to something less flattering than chemistry: **who actually follows through**.

Roommates who matched on being organized and reliable, not on other traits, rated their relationship higher months into living together. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

Over a year of living together, you and your roommate tend to grow more alike emotionally, and whichever of you has less pull in the relationship usually does more of the adjusting to get there.

Pairs who ended up more emotionally alike this way were also the ones who **stayed closer** and stuck together. [Source 5](#)

What to actually find out, and how

SAY

Skip the vibe check. Ask about a time they let something slide: 'What's something you said you'd do around a place and then didn't get to, and what happened after?'

The story they tell about a slip-up, including what they did next, is the real signal. [Source 2](#)

SAY

Letting a small annoyance slide feels easier than risking the good feeling by bringing it up. **Say it anyway**, while it's still small: 'It's been bugging me that ____, can we figure out a system?'

People who spoke up directly, rather than hinting or ignoring it, rated their roommate relationship higher. [Source 3](#)

WATCH

Watch how they handle a small disagreement, more than whether they seem easygoing or assertive.

Roommates who worked things out together were rated more satisfied; roommates who just pushed their own way weren't.

Pushing your own way didn't help satisfaction at all, and avoiding the problem outright left people even less satisfied. [Source 4](#)

Not getting a full say in who you live with

KNOW

Ending up with a roommate of a different race than you doesn't by itself make the relationship worse.

Same-race and cross-race roommate pairs, whether chosen or randomly assigned, rated their relationship quality about the same. [Source 6](#)

KNOW

Rooming with someone of a different race than you doesn't just avoid harm. It can grow into friendships across race you wouldn't have made otherwise.

Students paired with a cross-race roommate, by choice or at random, ended up with more friends of other races and warmer cross-race interactions. [Source 6](#)

Sources

1. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0265407508096700>
2. <https://doi.org/10.1111/1467-6494.t01-1-00005>
3. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cresp.2024.100192>
4. <https://doi.org/10.56816/2471-0032.1030>
5. <https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.84.5.1054>
6. <https://doi.org/10.1037/pspa0000393>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Living with housemates at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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